

Is AI bad for the environment?

Posted by u/Anarkhos2 • 0 points • 28 comments

I've been on this discussion for quite some time now. I've already made a ton of opinions about a lot of stuff in this subject, and even changed my views sometimes.

One of the few things that I still have not made an opinion about, is how good or bad AI is for the environment, because I lack the information and confidence to do so.

I made this post to see people's point of view, and perhaps try to discuss if possible.

So, what do you think?

Comments

u/Various-Yesterday-54 • 1 points • 2025-07-26 18:11 UTC

Anybody who eats meat cannot complain. The energy consumption of so many everyday things are so much worse, they just don't like AI.

u/lts_Stavro • 2 points • 2025-07-25 17:10 UTC

No it isn't, or at least it's one of the million energy intensive thing we do and no different and even if it's energy costly that doesn't condemn it because we can use nuclear energy and generally find ways to make energy cheaper that the amount of energy required will not be anything to worry because of energy being so widespread.

u/HunterIV4 • 4 points • 2025-07-25 16:56 UTC

AI is no better or worse for the environment than literally any other modern computer project with a large scale. Bitcoin mining alone uses similar levels of power as the entire AI industry, although that is likely changing soon (AI is frankly way more useful than crypto). When you compare it to the internet as a whole (just the internet, not technology in general), AI uses *maybe* 20% of data center energy, and all data centers combined are *maybe* 2% of global electricity usage.

So if we banned AI tomorrow, we would reduce global electricity usage by up to 0.4%.

So while AI's environmental impact is greater than zero, in the grand scheme of climate change risks, it's quite a bit below the "cow farts" range of catastrophic damage.

Now, this will increase over time as AI gets more integrated into things, but it will also gain efficiency over time as technology improves and we develop more chips optimized for inference logic rather than

repurposing video game graphics cards.

The real problem with climate change is that we haven't found a viable alternative to fossil fuels for energy. Electronics consumption in first world countries represents a tiny fraction of the world's CO2 production.

What we *should* be doing is sticking small nuclear power plants out in the desert somewhere and building the data centers next to them, but the Cold War *still* has everyone shook about nuclear and so we keep investing way too much into unreliable power sources without sufficient battery technology to make it viable for human needs. But nobody likes to talk about that.

If we assume AI has absolutely no positive economic value, which is dubious to say the least, it could get as high as 1% of global energy usage over the next 5-10 years, maybe 2% (although if it's truly not as useful as people think it might be, the rate of increase will probably not be as fast as if it *is* useful). The problem is that it's not a zero-sum game, and AI could also be beneficial.

As an obvious example, if more people asked ChatGPT to explain why taking a massive loan with high interest rates to buy a big pickup truck is a bad idea, and were actually convinced because a computer said it, that alone could take a chunk out of energy sectors that genuinely matter.

Wishful thinking? Maybe, maybe not, but the tech isn't going anywhere, so we are better served trying to find ways to reduce the impact of it (like nuclear or at least putting datacenters near hydro) rather than acting like we can put the genie back in the bottle. At this point it's like asking if we shouldn't shut down the internet.

u/Vanilla_Forest • 1 points • 2025-07-25 16:27 UTC

I wonder how many comments there were about the harm to the environment under one of the tens of thousands of videos with knives and steel balls heated to 1000 degrees.

u/Kristile-man • 2 points • 2025-07-25 16:26 UTC

if antis say that then they are a hypocritical mess

ai wastes much less than humans

u/Revegelance • 1 points • 2025-07-25 16:22 UTC

It is, but so is literally everything else we do. The carbon footprint of AI isn't any higher than other internet things, like social media, or even playing video games. The manufacture of your phone or computer used way more resources than probably all of the prompts that you could ever run on it. You could generate something like 700 images with the amount of water it takes to brew a cup of coffee.

u/pcalau12i_ • 1 points • 2025-07-25 16:17 UTC

It's more that burning fossil fuels is bad for the environment, and we do that to power AI so sure, but we also do that so people can post on reddit about how much they hate AI. It's not really an "AI problem" but an "energy infrastructure" problem, and blaming AI specifically kind of misses the forest for the trees.

u/Salindurthas • 2 points • 2025-07-25 16:16 UTC

It is difficult to compare for a few reasons:

* An individual prompt is usually cheap/low-energy

- * But training a model could be as much energy as you want to spend on it
- * And the automation enables large-scale and wasteful use of it, wasting energy on creating documents that might even be a net-detriment to humanity (like hundreds of sites each writing a dozen fake articles/reviews/recipes/etc every day to try to farm advert revenue. Or automated social media posts to fake engagement.)

u/WizardlyBump17 • 2 points • 2025-07-25 16:09 UTC

as said here, the problem is the data centers, not the ai per se.

It takes more energy to train a model than to use it. I can run ai locally on my pc that has a 550w psu and it takes like 10 seconds to generate a 1024x1024 image. I tried lora training and it takes ~30 minutes to train based on 10 images

u/2008knight • 1 points • 2025-07-25 16:11 UTC

30 minutes?! What kind of black magic did you use?!

u/WizardlyBump17 • 2 points • 2025-07-25 16:14 UTC

i should have more specific, but i used 10 images, most of them 512x512 and some with 512 pixels only in one axis. I trained the lora based on sd 1.5

u/2008knight • 1 points • 2025-07-25 16:23 UTC

Ah right... SD 1.5

That thing was so delightful to train.

u/IndigoFenix • 9 points • 2025-07-25 15:56 UTC

It uses **significantly** less energy on any given task than it would take for a human to perform a similar task.

However, when it is doing the work-equivalent of millions of people, those numbers add up.

The problem isn't that AI is doing it, it's that it can be - and often is - scaled up in ways that human populations generally aren't, and the competition between businesses pressure them to scale up as fast as possible when given the option.